physician, Dr. Lettsom, to visit them. He was esteemed by the prisoners.

The bread allowance is from the Chamber of London. Debtors (some of whom are from the Court of Conscience, and lie till their debts are paid[1]) have from the sheriffs thirty-two pounds of beef on Saturday. They had formerly from the Peacock brewhouse (Messrs. Calvert and Co.) a donation of two barrels of small beer a week. There are many legacies for common-side debtors, who receive them quarterly. The annual amount is £59 2s. 11d.

BRIDEWELL

This building was formerly a palace, near St. Bridget's (St. Bride's) well; from whence it had the name; which, after it became a prison, was applied to other prisons of the same sort.[2] It was given to the city by King Edward VI in 1552.

[1] As I shall frequently have occasion to mention this class of debtors, who are generally working people with large families, I think it may be proper to give some account of what are called Courts of Conscience. In 1518, the Common Council of the City of London passed an Act for the recovery of debts under forty shillings due to citizens, by a court to be called a Court of Conscience, held in Guildhall; and the debtors who refused to obey the award of that court, were to be imprisoned in one of the City Compters until they complied, although it were *durante vita*. In 1605 the powers of that court were established by Act of Parliament. In 1750 Alderman Dickenson brought in a Bill for extending similar powers to the whole county of Middlesex; with this difference, that all persons refusing to submit to the decision of the court were liable to be imprisoned in Newgate for three calendar months, which cancelled the debt. From these several Acts, others have been framed for various parts of the kingdom, in some of which the term of confinement has been limited to forty days. I have collected most of these, and find the expenses, fees, etc., to be very different; in some instances amounting to three or four times the original debt.

Now there appears to be a very obvious defect in the policy respecting this matter. Why should a man for the same debt be liable in one place to imprisonment for life, in another for three months, in another only for forty days? Why should the fees, etc., be the same for discharging a debt of fifteen pence (for such I have known a man imprisoned for), and for thirty-nine shillings? It is certainly desirable that one comprehensive statute for the whole kingdom, on this head, should be framed; wherein a proportion might be established between the sums indebted, and the fees and times of imprisonment. And particular care should be taken, that debtors of this kind be not suffered to mix with criminals, who by their instructions and example frequently render them as abandoned as themselves.

See, further, on this subject, a report drawn up by the committee of the benevolent Society for the Discharge and Relief of Persons Confined for Small Debts.

[2] Johnson's *Dictionary*.

That part of Bridewell which relates to my subject has wards for men and women quite separate. The men's ward on the ground-floor is a day-room in which they beat hemp; and, down two steps, a close night-room. At my late visits, a staircase was made to a room above, for the convenience of the prisoners. In both this and the night-room, a window has been lately stopped up. The women's ward is a day-room on the ground-floor, in which they beat hemp; and upstairs, two night-rooms. A chamber above these is fitted up for an infirmary. The sick were formerly sent to St. Bartholomew's Hospital. All the prisoners being kept within doors, makes it necessary to lime-white the rooms twice a year. The women's rooms are large, and have opposite windows, for fresh air. Their ward, as well as the men's, has water: and there is a hand ventilator on the outside, with a tube to each room of the women's ward: yet their rooms were offensive. The ventilator would be of service if more frequently worked, when the rooms are crowded with prisoners: there can, however, never be a healthy prison, where the prisoners are not at times permitted to breathe the fresh air in a court.

The prisoners are employed by a hemp-dresser, who has the profit of their labour, an apartment in the prison, and a salary of £20. I always found them at work: at my last visit they were picking oakum. The hours of work are in winter from eight to four; in summer from six to six, deducting meal-times. The steward is allowed eightpence a day for the maintenance of each prisoner; and contracts to supply them as follows—On Sunday, Monday, Tuesday and Thursday, a penny loaf, ten ounces of dressed beef without bone, broth, and three pints of ten shilling beer: on Wednesday, Friday and Saturday, a penny loaf, four ounces of cheese or some butter, a pint of milk-pottage, and three pints of beer. They are served with the day's allowance about twelve o'clock. The allowance of bread is too small, in August 1783, eight and a half ounces; October, nine ounces. The porter or keeper is Thomas Holt. Salary, £80; no fees. To the women's ward there is a matron, Sarah Lyon; salary, £60. She takes care of the sick, both men and women; and is allowed a shilling a day for those that are put on the sick diet. No bath.

In winter the women have some firing. All the night-rooms are supplied with rye-straw once a month. No other prison in London has any straw or bedding.

In Bridewell is a public chapel: the prisoners should attend